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Beebe Likes Denver First, Millers Second, Saints Third

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LOUISVILLE, Ky. — This is the time of the year when a baseball writer must sit down, collect his thoughts, if any, and with a nervous typewriter inform an eager public how the pennant race is going to come out.



Beebe

Then, if he's wise, he will forget all about what he wrote and hope no one reminds him of it.

This department had a

winner two years ago. He picked the Millers to win the American Association pennant and they did. But that one success has not made him cocky.

In fact, the pennant picking limb, right now, feels shakier than ever. There is no crystal ball lying around and concrete information is rather sketchy with rosters still being shuffled.

The Association clubs will start a little better set than usual because of the early major league cutdown, but parent clubs still can move players back and forth; still can wreck a good team with a couple of recalls.

So much for the prelim-

inary alibis. The annual chore must be done; so here goes. The eight clubs that start from scratch Tuesday will be lined up something like this when the curtain goes down Sept. 8:

1, Denver; 2, Minneapolis; 3, St. Paul; 4, Wichita; 5, Charleston; 6, Omaha; 7, Indianapolis; 8, Louisville.

There could be a good race between the first five teams, at least four of which should be stronger than last year.

Denver, which faltered in the stretch of 1956 and blew the pennant to Indianapolis, is picked again.

The Bears, it has been pointed out, don't figure to

be as strong as last year simply because their great outfield has been broken up. But there always is an inclination to string along with New York Yankee manpower from which Denver benefits.

The Yanks already have returned the AA home run king Marv Throneberry to play first base, and the Bears have thunder in their outfield bats as well as the promise of good pitching and infield defense.

Minneapolis, under Red Davis, should be better than last year with improved pitching, a nifty infield and some exceptionally fine rookies. If the kids come

through, if Rosy Ryan is successful in getting a little more lefthanded punch and gets another good pitcher, the Millers could go all the way. And if things do not break right, they could slip a notch or two.

St. Paul, after a series of second division finishes, starts better than it has in years. Max Macon has nearly every position well fortified and the Saints should be right in the thick of things all the way.

Wichita is looking for much better than the seventh place finish of its maiden AA year in 1956. Pitching should be a big factor in the Braves' climb. As

Fred Haney, Milwaukee manager recently told Rosy Ryan: "Wichita is getting at least three pitchers better than ones I must keep because I can't get them out of the league." Wichita has a new manager in Ben Geraghty.

Charleston climbed out of the cellar last year to finish sixth and should be further improved. Frank Skaiff is eying the first division and could make it with the right Detroit help. Good pitching there, too.

Omaha needs a lot of help and doesn't seem likely to get it from a depleted St. Louis Cardinal farm system.

Indianapolis will miss that Cleveland tieup that won two pennants in the last three years. The Chicago White Sox haven't the talent to give the Indians that Cleveland did, so Andy Cohen's managerial debut in the AA could be a rocky one.

Another former Miller, Dutch Meyer, has an even tougher task at Louisville. The Colonels started with nothing, are taking every crumb of help they can get. Everyone is wishing them well, but good wishes do not win ball games.

We have spoken—but we wish we had kept our trap shut.